

The devils of tomorrow

Over the past decade, I've noticed a trend of sorts. Between 2001 and 2006, a majority of the mail we received from readers was virus troubleshooting in nature. Those were the days when almost everyone was running Windows 98 or XP, and we always seemed to find new and interesting ways of screwing things up. Using computers was always a frustrating experience, but we learned from it.

However, in the past three to four years at Digit – although the actual volume of email we receive has gone up by orders of magnitudes – we've noted a rapid decline in troubleshooting emails. It's mostly about "What should I buy?" these days. Are PC problems a thing of the past? Has the security software out there just got better, or is it the Windows OS? Perhaps the malware makers have all given up...

I remember slip-streaming an antivirus and spyware software into my installer copy of XP, because I knew sooner or later I'd need to format, and I didn't want to be unprotected for even five minutes on a network or the internet. These days, it's quite a different story. Windows 7 is one of the most secure OSes Microsoft has ever put out, and the free Microsoft Security Essentials (MSE) just sweetens the deal.

I'm not running about anymore looking to download a firewall, or desperate to keep my anti-spyware program updated, or ensuring that I have a USB drive with HijackThis and Process Explorer on it. Of course I still have anti-virus software (I'm not stupid) – a free version at home and a company-paid-for version at work. Thanks to more secure browsers, I don't worry too much about malicious sites, and because I own a smart phone, I spend more time trying out apps than I do looking for new software for my PC.

Am I the exception or the norm?

In a country where mobile penetration is magnitudes higher than PC penetration, and smartphone sales are skyrocketing, I think I'm the norm. In this mobile age, are we really more secure than we were a decade ago? The stories in this issue stem from this question.

The most common mistake we make is to assume that because there are only a handful of mobile malware as opposed to millions for

the PC platform, our mobiles are safe. What we're experiencing right now is the calm before the storm – with OSes such as Android becoming popular and apps coming out by the thousands, expect this to change. In fact, in one of the stories in this issue you will be introduced to some malware that already targets the Android platform. Sure, they don't really do much damage right now, but wait and watch.

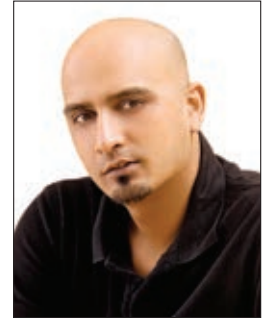
What will be instrumental in changing mobile security is the huge upheaval that's coming in mobile processing – thanks to brand new system-on-a-chip (SoC) designs, we're going to have mobiles that will be powerful enough to play HD videos and 3D games using multi-core parallel processing, and also bring more functions of the traditional PC to your phone. All this processing power will obviously bring smarter OSes, and as a result, smarter and more powerful malware. Read the article on SoC in this issue for more details.

Will companies be shifting focus away from desktop security suites for end users soon? Are paid security suites for home users are just dying a slow death because of free software such as MSE? We interviewed a few security companies to get their take.

Security companies and desktop OS makers alike are now battle-hardened veterans, and we users are no different. The truth is that we've gotten so good at tackling PC viruses, that we don't fear them as much anymore. Yet we never think about securing the other devices we use, which probably have a lot more personal information than our PCs. This is what needs to change – rapidly.

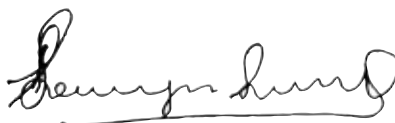
With 3G, many more of us will be always-on, and from anywhere, using devices that thus far aren't thought of as insecure. If we aren't careful, we'll end up being as flabbergasted as the ARPANET scientists were when they discovered the very first virus, back in 1971.

The devils you know might be easier to deal with, but it's the ones you don't that will dictate how secure you are tomorrow. 



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